

NEWSPRINT

immediate offering. HP intends to offer an upgrade for users of the portable computer when Symphony is made available.

Robin Webster in the US.

Team approach to educational software

Two Sydney educational psychologists are turning their beliefs into a business with what they believe is a first in software for learning.

Their business, Computer Tutor, has recently released its first educational software program 'Basic Arithmetic and Algebra'.

The second, 'English: Sentence Construction', is scheduled for release in early June.

What's new about these

programs (designed for use on a Commodore 64 or SX-64) according to John and Mary Ann Paynter is that they apply some very solid principles of learning never before applied in educational software.

John Paynter, managing director of Computer Tutor, says all other software he and his wife and partner Mary Ann have seen has been produced by teachers or programmers or both.

"What has been missing is the third vitally important and equally specialised area of knowledge — the psychology of learning. That's the key to a really effective piece of educational software."

"We have a team approach where the original content is supplied by a teacher, we supply the principles of learning and the programmer puts in the technical expertise that

makes the programs work effectively for students in schools or in the home.

"For home use, its very much like having a private coach coming into the home but a lot less expensive", John said.

Content on the tapes or disks is geared to the NSW HSC syllabus for Year 11 and 12 students and has "already found much acceptance in the marketplace".

"We were particularly gratified that after our participation in the Centrepoint exhibition in March this year, people were buying our software first, then seeking our advice on the best hardware to go with it. We use the Commodore 64 ourselves and that's what the programs are designed for."

The learning principles being applied by the Paynters are the widely acknowledged Skinnerian principles "plus advances in this field over the last fifty years".

"The learning is not done on our programs by the drill and practice method of so much educational software, but through the teaching of real conceptual material," John points out.

Applying these principles, the Paynters plan to cover all the subjects of the NSW HSC syllabus inside the next two years.

Although professional and market place response to their product has already been "very, very encouraging", Mary Ann is also currently working with the Departments of Psychology and Education at the University of Sydney to get professionally valid test results on their programs.

"The principles we use have been more than amply proven in the last fifty years," she explains, "but our business philosophy is that we will continually test and improve our products, based on valid research."

"It's important not to say

'students who use this program learn better than others', but to really know that's true, and be able to illustrate why."

Computer Tutor programs are currently being distributed through Ozi-Soft but the Paynters are discussing distribution and marketing possibilities with several large multi-nationals.

Entrance stage right . . .

The Roadrunner, according to President Computers its Australian distributors, is "the ant's pants when it comes to a portable machine". The full colour brochure calls it "the first truly portable computer". Dulmont Magnum might find that disagreeable. The machine weighs just over two kilograms, is battery powered and has an 80 column 8 line LCD display. It has a CMOS cpu running a "CP/M compatible operating system" in 64k of memory.

Like the NEC 8201, the Roadrunner has removable battery-back RAM cartridges each of up to 16k. It also has program cartridges containing a text editor, Microsoft Basic and SuperCalc. Built into its 16k ROM are a couple of name/address/schedule type programs and a DEC VT100 terminal emulation package.

Parallel and serial ports are included in the (exclusive of sales tax) price of \$1,799.

Yankee speak

On the 1st and 2nd of August, the Yankee Group will be holding its second seminar for '84 titled "The IBM Impact" at Sydney's Hyatt Kingsgate Hotel.

Topics include IBM Networking, IBM in the home and office automation. The attendance fee is \$595. Details on (02) 399 8200.

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